

THE KUIPER BELT

The Kuiper Belt is a vast zone beyond the orbit of Neptune with large icy bodies. When Pluto was discovered, astronomers called it “planet nine”, but we now know it is just one of the thousands of Kuiper Belt Objects (KBOs). In 2015, the New Horizons spacecraft showed Pluto has icy mountains and plains of frozen nitrogen. The craft is now heading to a KBO called 2014MU₆₉.

DATA FILE



DISTANCE FROM SUN:
4.5–10 billion km (2.8–6 billion miles)



FIRST KBO DISCOVERED: Pluto (1930)



SMALLEST KBO: 65407 (2002 RP120),
15 km (9 miles) in diameter



LARGEST KBO: Pluto, 2,370 km
(1,470 miles) in diameter

Largely made of ice, mixed with rocky pebbles, the temperature on a KBO is usually -220°C (-364°F)